Group 1 — Fortress North: protect it with guns

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Our position: Sovereignty you cannot enforce is a sovereignty you do not have. Canada has spent 50 years *saying* the Arctic is ours while relying on American submarines to actually watch it. That era is over. Build the fleet, build the bases, and make any intruder, Russian or American, calculate the cost.

Briefing

For most of the year, Canada cannot see what is happening under the ice of its own archipelago. The Royal Canadian Navy's four Victoria-class submarines were built for Britain in the early 1990s and bought second-hand in 1998. They cannot operate under ice. Canada's most powerful icebreaker, the CCGS *Louis S. St-Laurent*, has been in service since 1969. The six Arctic patrol ships the navy does have can only work the Northwest Passage from roughly June to October, and large parts of that passage remain uncharted (Economy.ac, Oct. 27, 2026).

That is starting to change, and this group's job is to argue it must change faster. In 2026 Ottawa opened negotiations with Germany's Thyssenkrupp Marine Systems for up to 12 conventionally powered, under-ice-capable submarines, with the first four to arrive in 2034 (Canada.ca, July 2026). Canada and Norway are building a wider defence partnership around the same Type 212CD design and a joint Arctic surveillance dialogue (Defence Industry Europe, Sept. 21, 2026). The March 2026 northern plan put $32 billion into forward operating locations at Yellowknife, Inuvik, Iqaluit and Goose Bay, with the stated aim of letting the Canadian Armed Forces defend the Arctic *without* allied help (ReNew Canada, Mar. 16, 2026). Roughly $28 billion over 20 years is going into NORAD modernization, including over-the-horizon radar expected to reach initial capability by 2029 (Economy.ac, Aug. 2026).

Why the urgency? Foreign Affairs Minister Anita Anand told Euronews in July 2026 that the Russian threat is moving steadily north toward the Arctic Circle, and Russia operates at least 17 military bases above it (Streamline Feed, July 8, 2026). On March 4, 2026, NORAD tracked two Russian Tu-142 maritime patrol aircraft in the Alaskan air defence zone (Hashtag Investing, Sept. 2026). Meanwhile, the Trump administration's National Security Strategy named the Northwest Passage a key strategic location, and Washington has never accepted that the Passage is Canadian internal water (Policy Magazine, Feb. 2026).

Some in this camp go further than the government. A Queen's University policy brief argued that only nuclear-powered submarines can patrol under ice for weeks at a time, and that with Canada–US relations cooling, Canada may need its own (CIDP, Queen's).

> "Every August a foreign warship could sail through the Passage, and we would find out from a satellite photo. A flag is not a fence. A submarine is a fence." — *Cmdr. (ret.) Doug Ferrier, former Arctic patrol officer* **[illustrative]**

Quotations marked [illustrative] are fictional composite voices written for readability. Real public figures are paraphrased from the linked reports.